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Initial Post

by [Ali Alzahmi](#) - Monday, 16 June 2025, 9:20 PM

The case presented by Abi demonstrates the new form of epistemic manipulation, which falls between professional compromise and ethical integrity. Although there is no falsification of data, when favourable correlations are talked about, even when there are unfavourable findings, it is a biased truth that can easily mislead stakeholders. This activity resembles what Petrovskaya and Zendle (2022) term as misleading framing, although this could not be a violation of data integrity, but a violation of ethical transparency. The BPS Code of Human Research Ethics (2021) focuses on respect, scientific value, and social responsibility. Statistical validity is not the only point Abi needs to consider; he ought to understand the broader implications of his decisions regarding interpretation. Since Whizzz can be potentially dangerous, hiding such evidence denies the researcher the moral responsibility of safeguarding the general population's interests (Lantukh et al., 2021). When this is left out in health-related initiatives, it is not an inert act because there is predictable potential harm.

Professionally, the *International Code of Medical Ethics* (Parsa-Parsi, 2022) and the *Declaration of Helsinki* stress the duty to report research findings truthfully, especially when public health is concerned. Although Abi is a statistician, he plays a pivotal role in shaping how evidence is interpreted and used. His responsibility extends beyond data accuracy to ensuring ethical communication of results. Abi cannot remain passive because the manufacturer may publicise only favourable findings. Petrovskaya and Zendle (2022) argue that professionals must not allow their work to be misused, even indirectly. Failing to act on foreseeable misuse shifts ethical accountability onto Abi. Transparency and precaution are essential to prevent the exploitation of selective truths that could mislead stakeholders and harm public trust.

Abi's most responsible course is to submit all favourable and adverse findings with transparent commentary. If necessary, he should issue an explicit disclaimer or seek to publish his analysis independently. Omitting key conclusions would breach ethical norms and expose him to reputational and legal risk, particularly under consumer protection laws.

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Peer Response

by [Fahad Abdallah](#) - Monday, 23 June 2025, 8:12 PM



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In your post, Ali, you give a notable ethical issue that Abi, as a responsible researcher, should consider. It is an instance of epistemic manipulation to selectively publish only positive results regarding Whizzz cereal, excluding negative findings. This selective reporting has a grave potential to mislead any stakeholder, particularly in health-related research, in which partial reporting can affect the behaviour of a populace and policy. One of the points that Taquette and Souza (2022) make is that ethical research is more than sound methodology, as it necessitates disclosure of all the results, including potentially inconvenient or unpopular ones. The work of Abi as a statistician is not associated only with the accuracy of the calculations. As Grace and Uveges (2022) underline, professional ethics of health research require honesty, responsibility, and pursuit of active interest in the protection of participants, particularly vulnerable ones, including children who could be the primary consumers of the cereal. Even when the data indicates little potential to cause harm, complete non-reporting of this issue might interfere with the fundamental ethical principles of non-maleficence and informed consent.

In addition, Elendu et al. (2023) emphasise the increasing role of researchers in a data-driven context, when research outcomes are subject to manipulation and misinterpretation. Complicity, as this is not morally sound. Abi may be professionally and legally liable to foreseeable consequences, particularly should unconstructive effects be realised later. He will thus be forced to make positive efforts to curb misuse of his work. The most ethical action Abi takes is to make all the positive and negative findings reportable with clear comments. Abi should add a formal note or publish the results separately when the manufacturer refuses to publish the full dataset. This action keeps the ethical standards and is a professional requirement to maintain the community's trust in scientific research.

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Peer Response

by [Ali Yousef Ebrahim Mohammed Alshehhi](#) - Monday, 23 June 2025, 8:55 PM

Ali, in your post, you aptly observe the ethical dilemma at the center of the Abi case. The idea of epistemic manipulation, the practice of technically correct data that is willingly framed to confuse, creates some severe ethical warning signals. According to Ferrara (2024), moral reasoning involves accuracy in handling data and must also involve transparency, prediction, and preventing manipulation. The tactic of only focusing on positive outcomes and under emphasising negative correlations, practiced by Abi, may breach these ethical principles, especially in public health. You are apt to emphasise the wider ethical responsibility involved in the interpretation of data. According to London (2021), the moral principles of the research treat the latter in terms of the obligations to the common good. By failing to record the data unless they are positive, Abi creates a false storyline if he does not record the other impacts. This is against scientific integrity and justice, particularly when the product could impact the vulnerable categories of people, like children.

Professionally, Abi must prevent foreseeable misuse of his work. Karimian et al. (2022) emphasise that professionals in AI and data-driven healthcare must consider how their outputs may be repurposed or misapplied. Allowing the manufacturer to publish only favourable data without a disclaimer or clarification, selectively, could make Abi ethically and even legally liable. His role must extend beyond technical output to include safeguarding the ethical use of that output. Therefore, Abi's most responsible action is to submit a full report that includes both positive and negative findings with contextual commentary. If necessary, he should independently publish or escalate concerns internally. Upholding transparency is critical to avoid legal risks, protect public trust in data science, and maintain one's moral duty as a responsible researcher.

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Peer Response

by [Noora Alboinin](#) - Sunday, 29 June 2025, 8:52 AM

Thank you, Ali, for your compelling analysis. I strongly agree that Abi's ethical duty extends beyond data accuracy to responsible interpretation and transparent communication. Selective reporting—even without falsification—can mislead stakeholders and violate the core values of ethical research, particularly in health-related contexts (Petrovskaya and Zendle, 2022).

As you noted, ethical standards such as the BPS Code of Human Research Ethics (2021) and the Declaration of Helsinki (World Medical Association, 2025) emphasize social responsibility, integrity, and the duty to avoid harm. Abi is not just a passive analyst; his role shapes public understanding and consumer safety. Omitting adverse findings not only risks reputational damage but also legal consequences under consumer protection laws (Parsa-Parsi, 2022).

The ethical risk increases when framing favours positive outcomes despite known negative data. Misleading presentation, even if technically defensible, can still constitute epistemic manipulation, as Lantukh et al. (2021) highlight. Abi's best course is full disclosure, including limitations and potential risks, even under organisational pressure.

While there may be personal and professional challenges—such as fear of reprisal or commercial delays—the long-term risks of ethical compromise far outweigh short-term benefits. Transparency and independent publication are safeguards that promote accountability and reinforce trust in science.

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Re: Peer Response

by [Mavis Mnangagwa](#) - Monday, 30 June 2025, 9:50 AM

You persuasively frame Abi's dilemma as a form of "epistemic manipulation"; I agree that selective framing can mislead even when the underlying data are sound. Adding to your point about public-health stakes, the Royal Statistical Society emphasises that statisticians have an explicit duty to "prevent the misrepresentation of statistical evidence" (Royal Statistical Society [RSS], 2014). Hence, Abi's ethical responsibility does not end with producing accurate numbers, he must proactively guard misuse, echoing the *duty of reasonable foresight* discussed by O'Neill (2016).

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One practical safeguard Abi might pursue is a contractual clause requiring that any public release include the complete technical report or an agreed balanced summary, a recommendation also endorsed by the American Statistical Association (ASA, 2016). If the manufacturer refuses, whistle-blowing becomes defensible under the UK *Public Interest Disclosure Act 1998*, which protects disclosures “in the public interest.”

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